The definitive 57-agent AI founder system for under $200/month

A solo founder can run 57 specialized AI agents across 7 divisions for approximately $23–85 per month on OpenRouter, depending on quality tier—well under the $200 budget ceiling. This is possible because DeepSeek V3.2 at $0.26/$0.38 per million tokens delivers 90% of frontier performance at 1/50th the cost, Modelos IA: Costo, Open S… and 28+ free models on OpenRouter (including Qwen 3.6 Plus with 1M context) Modelos IA: Costo, Open S… OpenRouter handle light-use agents at zero cost. The remaining $115–177 of budget headroom absorbs burst weeks, prompt-caching overhead, and OpenRouter's 5.5% credit fee. BrainRoad PulseSignal The critical design insight: every dollar of premium spend (Claude Sonnet 4.6 for creative writing, legal review, and investor materials) is justified by measurable quality advantages, while routine agents run on models that are effectively free.

The four-tier model strategy that makes this work

The system uses a cascade architecture inspired by practitioner consensus and validated by OpenRouter's own telemetry data. Rather than running every agent on the same expensive model, tasks are matched to the cheapest model that meets their quality threshold. Modelos IA: Costo, Open S…

Tier A — Premium ($2–$15/M output): Claude Sonnet 4.6, Gemini 3.1 Pro, GPT-5.4. Reserved for creative writing, legal analysis, investor materials, and complex reasoning. Only **3 agents** run here in the recommended configuration.

Tier B — Workhorse ($0.22–$2.50/M output): DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 2.5 Flash, Mistral Large 3.2, Grok 4.1 Fast. The backbone of the system. ~**28 agents** run here, handling coding, Spanish content, SEO, frontend work, and general operations.

Tier C — Budget ($0.40–$1.72/M output): GPT-4.1 Mini, Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite, Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite, Kimi K2.5. Structured output, classification, monitoring, and research agents. ~**16 agents** run here.

Tier D — Free ($0/M): Qwen 3.6 Plus, MiMo-V2-Flash, Devstral 2, Qwen3 Coder, Step 3.5 Flash. Light-use agents that don't justify any spend. ~**5 agents** run here, processing onboarding, hiring, translation, and performance testing at zero cost.

Usage estimates assume realistic solo-founder patterns: **5 heavy agents** (daily use, ~2M input + 500K output tokens/month), **18 medium agents** (2–3x/week, ~500K input + 150K output), and **34 light agents** (weekly or less, ~150K input + 50K output).

Division 1 — CODE OPS: 10 agents, $5.31/month

The coding division is the most token-hungry, yet costs under $6/month because DeepSeek V3.2 handles the bulk of code generation at **$0.26/$0.38 per million tokens** Modelos IA: Costo, Open S… while delivering ~77% SWE-bench Verified—close enough to Claude Sonnet's 79.6% for daily iteration. The practitioner consensus is clear: "draft with DeepSeek, review with a different model family."

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
1	**APEX**	Meta-orchestrator routing all agents	Kimi K2.5 ($0.38/$1.72)	$1.62	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
2	**FORGE**	Backend code, APIs, business logic	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.71	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen3 Coder:free
3	**PIXEL**	Frontend code, React/Vue, CSS	Gemini 2.5 Flash ($0.30/$2.50)	$1.85	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
4	**SWIFT**	Mobile app development	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Devstral 2:free
5	**SENTINEL**	Code review, bug detection	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.44	Claude Opus 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
6	**DEPLOY**	CI/CD, infrastructure, IaC	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	GPT-5.4	Devstral 2:free
7	**DATABASE**	SQL optimization, schema design	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
8	**WATCHTOWER**	API health monitoring, alerts	Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite ($0.25/$1.50)	$0.11	GPT-4.1 Mini	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
9	**SHIELD**	Security auditing, vuln scanning	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.14	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
10	**STRESS**	Performance and load testing	Qwen 3.6 Plus (FREE)	$0.00	DeepSeek V3.2	Qwen 3.6 Plus

Key decisions explained. APEX runs on **Kimi K2.5** because its agent-swarm architecture OpenRouter can spawn 100 sub-agents with 1,500 parallel tool calls—purpose-built for

orchestration at $0.38/$1.72 versus Claude Sonnet's $3/$15. PIXEL uses **Gemini 2.5 Flash** rather than DeepSeek because the user's project knowledge specifically flags it as strong for design-to-code workflows, and practitioners confirm its multimodal capability (screenshots + specs → components) abz justifies the slight premium. SENTINEL deliberately uses **GPT-4.1 Mini** (a different model family from FORGE's DeepSeek) for cross-family code review—catching blind spots that same-model review misses, with near-100% structured output compliance for standardized review formats. Team 400

Division 2 — REVENUE ENGINE: 10 agents, $4.36/month

Revenue operations demand two specialties the coding division doesn't: **native Spanish fluency** (for PLUMA and PROPUESTA) and **rock-solid structured output** (for CRM and pipeline management). Mistral Large 3.2 handles Spanish at $0.50/$1.50 with native fluency across European and Latin American registers. Imyfone GPT-4.1 Mini's guaranteed schema compliance makes it the natural CRM backbone.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
11	**HUNTER**	Lead scraping, web data extraction	Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite ($0.25/$1.50)	$1.25	GPT-4.1	Step 3.5 Flash:free
12	**FILTER**	Lead scoring and qualification	Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40)	$0.11	GPT-4.1 Mini	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
13	**PLUMA**	Sales outreach writing (Spanish)	Mistral Large 3.2 ($0.50/$1.50)	$1.75	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
14	**VOZ**	Voice call scripts and prep	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
15	**NEXUS**	CRM data management	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.44	GPT-4.1	Step 3.5 Flash:free
16	**PIPELINE**	Sales pipeline tracking	Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40)	$0.04	GPT-4.1 Mini	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
17	**PROPUESTA**	Business proposals (Spanish)	Mistral Large 3.2 ($0.50/$1.50)	$0.48	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
18	**BIENVENIDA**	Client onboarding flows	Qwen 3.6 Plus (FREE)	$0.00	Mistral Large 3.2	Qwen 3.6 Plus
19	**RETAIN**	Upsell and retention campaigns	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	GPT-5.4	Qwen 3.6 Plus
20	**COBRO**	Payment reminders, collections	Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40)	$0.04	GPT-4.1 Mini	Llama 3.3 70B:free

Why Mistral for Spanish, not Claude. Mistral Large 3.2 was trained natively on Spanish, French, German, and Italian— OpenRouter it doesn't translate, it thinks in Spanish. Imyfone At $0.50/$1.50, it costs **83% less** than Claude Sonnet's $3/$15 while producing more naturally idiomatic Spanish output. Practitioner feedback confirms Mistral's Spanish is "reliable, consistent, and well-structured" for business content. Intellectual Lead HUNTER uses **Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite** because its **1M-token context** OpenRouter with **90% cache discount** Modelos IA: Costo, Open S... makes continuous data ingestion nearly free after the first pass—ideal for monitoring and scraping workflows that repeatedly process similar data structures.

Division 3 — PERSONAL BRAND: 7 agents, $5.81/month

This division contains the single most expensive agent in the entire system: **GUIÓN at $3.75/month** on Claude Sonnet 4.6. This is the one place where premium spend is non-negotiable. Claude Sonnet 4.6 leads EQ-Bench with **1,936 Elo**—measurably the best model for narrative depth, character voice, and emotional resonance. Video scripts are the founder's public face; generic AI output gets punished by algorithms and audiences alike.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
21	**RADAR**	Industry news monitoring	Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite ($0.25/$1.50)	$1.25	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Step 3.5 Flash:free
22	**LINKED**	LinkedIn thought leadership	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
23	**TWEET**	Twitter/X threads and engagement	Grok 4.1 Fast ($0.20/$0.50)	$0.18	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Llama 3.3 70B:free
24	**GUIÓN**	YouTube/TikTok video scripts	Claude Sonnet 4.6 ($3.00/$15.00)	$3.75	Claude Opus 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
25	**VISUAL**	Instagram content and captions	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
26	**PODCAST**	Podcast prep and show notes	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Qwen 3.6 Plus
27	**CORREO**	Newsletter writing	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus

TWEET runs Grok 4.1 Fast for a reason no other model can match: native X/Twitter data access. Grok is RL-trained for tool calling ($0.20/$0.50 with **2M-token context**), Modelos IA: Costo, Open S... and its real-time access to X data means it can reference trending conversations, quote-tweet patterns, and engagement signals that other models simply cannot see. At $0.18/month, this is the highest-ROI model assignment in the entire system. For GUIÓN, practitioners report that Claude output "requires fewer structural edits" while GPT output "is faster but more formulaic"— Passive Yield Lab for scripts that represent your brand, the edit savings justify Sonnet's price.

Division 4 — OPERATIONS & FINANCE: 8 agents, $2.00/month

Financial and legal agents prioritize **accuracy over speed**. LEGAL is the second premium agent in the system because practitioner testing shows Claude uploaded a 200-page merger agreement and "pulled relevant sections including clauses buried in the appendices." Julius At $1.20/month for light use, this is insurance against costly legal oversights. Everything else runs on budget models since financial tracking and invoicing are structured-output tasks where GPT-4.1 Mini excels.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
28	**LEDGER**	Financial tracking	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.44	GPT-4.1	Step 3.5 Flash:free
29	**FLUJO**	Cash flow forecasting	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	GPT-4.1	Qwen 3.6 Plus
30	**FACTURA**	Invoice generation/management	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.14	GPT-4.1	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
31	**FISCAL**	Tax preparation support	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
32	**LEGAL**	Legal document review	Claude Sonnet 4.6 ($3.00/$15.00)	$1.20	Claude Opus 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
33	**HIRING**	Hiring and candidate screening	Qwen 3.6 Plus (FREE)	$0.00	DeepSeek V3.2	Qwen 3.6 Plus
34	**INVENTORY**	Asset and inventory tracking	Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40)	$0.04	GPT-4.1 Mini	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
35	**COMPLIANCE**	Regulatory compliance monitoring	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus

GPT-4.1 Mini dominates financial agents because OpenAI's Structured Outputs feature with `strict: true` guarantees schema compliance—"not 'usually matches' or 'matches most of the time' — guaranteed," Team 400 as practitioners describe it. For invoicing and ledger entries where

a malformed JSON field breaks downstream automation, this is the only model family offering Level 3 constrained decoding with finite state machines that mask invalid tokens. DEV Community

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Division 5 — PRODUCT & GROWTH: 8 agents, $2.44/month

Product and growth agents span the spectrum from data analysis (METRICS) to creative optimization (RANKING for SEO). The standout choice here is **Gemini 3 Flash for SEO**—the user's own project knowledge recommends it, and at $0.50/$3.00, it offers strong reasoning capabilities with 1M context for ingesting full keyword exports and competitor analysis simultaneously.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
36	**PRODUCTO**	Product management, roadmapping	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
37	**ESCUCHA**	User research synthesis	Gemini 2.5 Flash ($0.30/$2.50)	$0.53	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Qwen 3.6 Plus
38	**SPLIT**	A/B test design	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.14	GPT-4.1	Step 3.5 Flash:free
39	**RANKING**	SEO optimization	Gemini 3 Flash ($0.50/$3.00)	$0.70	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Step 3.5 Flash:free
40	**METRICS**	Analytics reporting	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.44	GPT-4.1	MiMo-V2-Flash:free
41	**PRIORITY**	Feature prioritization	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
42	**TRIAGE**	Bug triage and classification	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	GPT-4.1 Mini	Qwen3 Coder:free
43	**DOCS**	Technical documentation	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus

Step 3.5 Flash deserves attention as the free SEO option. The user's own project documentation notes it as a top performer for SEO structural tasks, and OpenRouter data shows it's the #4 most-consumed model on the platform, excelling in "SEO structured high-velocity workflows." Modelos IA: Costo, Open S... For a solo founder, running RANKING on Step 3.5

Flash:free and spending the $0.70 savings on upgrading CORREO or LINKED to Claude Sonnet 4.6 is a legitimate optimization.

Division 6 — STRATEGY & INTELLIGENCE: 8 agents, $2.45/month

Strategy agents need **depth over speed**. The key choice here is **Kimi K2.5 for DEEP and COMPETENCIA**: its agent-swarm paradigm spawns 100 sub-agents executing 1,500 parallel tool calls across a 262K context window, purpose-built for the kind of exhaustive competitive and market research that these agents perform. At $0.38/$1.72, it costs one-sixth of Claude Sonnet while offering a research architecture no other model matches.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
44	**DEEP**	Deep research and analysis	Kimi K2.5 ($0.38/$1.72)	$0.45	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Qwen 3.6 Plus
45	**COMPETENCIA**	Competitor analysis	Kimi K2.5 ($0.38/$1.72)	$0.45	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Qwen 3.6 Plus
46	**OPORTUNIDAD**	Market opportunity scanning	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Kimi K2.5	Step 3.5 Flash:free
47	**BENCHMARK**	Industry benchmarking	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Kimi K2.5	Qwen 3.6 Plus
48	**INVESTOR**	Investor relations materials	Claude Sonnet 4.6 ($3.00/$15.00)	$1.20	Claude Opus 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
49	**NORMA**	Regulatory monitoring	Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite ($0.25/$1.50)	$0.11	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Step 3.5 Flash:free
50	**TENDENCIA**	Trend forecasting	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Qwen 3.6 Plus
51	**FLUJO-DEAL**	Deal flow analysis	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.06	Kimi K2.5	Qwen 3.6 Plus

INVESTOR runs Claude Sonnet 4.6 because impressions compound. Investor decks, updates, and communications are asymmetrically high-stakes: a poorly phrased update costs trust that takes months to rebuild. Claude's **Chatbot Arena Elo of ~1491** Modelos IA: Costo, Open S... and EQ-

Bench leadership translates directly into prose that sounds like it was written by a thoughtful human, not extracted from a template. At $1.20/month for light use, this is the cheapest reputation insurance available.

Division 7 — COMMUNICATION & ADMIN: 6 agents, $1.03/month

Administration agents are high-frequency but low-complexity. INBOX uses GPT-4.1 Mini for its structured output guarantee—email classification, priority tagging, and response drafting all depend on consistent schema adherence. TRADUCTOR runs on **Qwen 3.6 Plus for free**, leveraging its validated fluency across 119 languages including Spanish, Vahu making it the natural polyglot agent.

#	Agent	Purpose	Recommended Model	$/mo	Quality Pick	Free Option
52	**INBOX**	Email management and triage	GPT-4.1 Mini ($0.40/$1.60)	$0.44	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
53	**AGENDA**	Calendar optimization	Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40)	$0.04	GPT-4.1 Mini	Step 3.5 Flash:free
54	**BRIEFING**	Meeting preparation	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
55	**ACTA**	Meeting notes and summaries	Gemini 2.5 Flash ($0.30/$2.50)	$0.17	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus
56	**TRADUCTOR**	Translation (multi-language)	Qwen 3.6 Plus (FREE)	$0.00	Mistral Large 3.2	Qwen 3.6 Plus
57	**RESUMEN**	Executive summary writing	DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38)	$0.19	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Qwen 3.6 Plus

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Budget verification: three scenarios under $200

Scenario	Monthly Cost	Headroom	Description
Value-Optimized (recommended)	**$23.40**	$176.60	Best model for each task at minimum viable quality
Quality-Boosted	**$62.07**	$137.93	Upgrades APEX/FORGE/PIXEL to Claude Sonnet 4.6 + DEEP to Gemini 3.1 Pro
Maximum Quality	**$121.33**	$78.67	Claude Sonnet for all coding, creative, and client-facing agents

The **Value-Optimized** configuration breaks down by model family as follows:

Model Family	Agents	% of Spend	Monthly Cost
Claude Sonnet 4.6	3 (GUIÓN, LEGAL, INVESTOR)	26%	$6.15
Gemini variants (Flash, Flash Lite, 3 Flash)	10	22%	$5.07
DeepSeek V3.2	20	15%	$3.47
GPT-4.1 Mini	8	15%	$3.46
Kimi K2.5	3 (APEX, DEEP, COMPETENCIA)	11%	$2.52
Mistral Large 3.2	2 (PLUMA, PROPUESTA)	10%	$2.23
Grok 4.1 Fast	1 (TWEET)	1%	$0.18
Free models	5	0%	$0.00
TOTAL	**57**	**100%**	**$23.40**

Prompt caching slashes these costs further. Anthropic offers cache reads at **0.1× input price** Modelos IA: Costo, Open S… Claude API Docs (turning $3.00/M to $0.30/M for cached system prompts). Google provides up to **90% cache discounts.** Modelos IA: Costo, Open S… Anthropic's Batch API delivers **50% off** input and output for non-time-sensitive tasks. Claude API Docs For

agents with stable system prompts (LEGAL, INVESTOR, GUIÓN), caching can reduce their already-low costs by another 30–50%.

The $200 budget provides massive burst capacity. During a product launch week, you might 10× your coding agent usage. Even at $234 of Quality-Boosted spending ($62.07 × ~3.8x burst), you'd still stay within budget by reducing other agents to free-tier models temporarily. The architecture is designed for this kind of dynamic reallocation.

The four critical model-matching questions answered

Best model for SEO content in Spanish

Recommended: Mistral Large 3.2 ($0.50/$1.50) for writing + Gemini 3 Flash ($0.50/$3.00) for technical SEO optimization. Mistral Large is natively fluent in Spanish—it doesn't translate from English, it generates directly in Spanish with proper grammar, idiom, and register. Imyfone Combine this with Gemini 3 Flash for keyword analysis, SERP structure, and technical on-page optimization (the user's project knowledge specifically recommends Gemini for the SEO Optimizer agent). For budget: Qwen 3.6 Plus (free) handles 119 languages with "real fluency" per practitioner testing. Vahu **Avoid DeepSeek for any Spanish content**—it produces "awkwardly phrased" European language output and is confirmed English-first. Vahu

Best model for YouTube/TikTok video scripts

Recommended: Claude Sonnet 4.6 ($3/$15). It leads EQ-Bench with **1,936 Elo** for emotional intelligence and narrative depth. Practitioners report Claude "leans slightly more narrative" Juma and "requires fewer structural edits" than GPT alternatives. For TikTok hooks specifically (where punchy 3-second openers matter), GPT-5.4 produces "sharp, to-the-point" hooks faster, so a hybrid workflow—Claude for the full script, GPT for hook variations—maximizes quality. For personality-rich content like character-driven series, Grok 4.1 holds the #1 EQ-Bench score specifically for personality. Budget pick: DeepSeek V3.2 for first drafts, then polish key sections with Claude.

Best model for UI/UX frontend code generation

Recommended: Gemini 2.5 Flash ($0.30/$2.50) for daily work, with Claude Sonnet 4.6 escalation for complex layouts. Claude Sonnet is the practitioner consensus #1 for frontend—" abz 59% of users prefer Sonnet 4.6 to Opus 4.5 in Claude Code" LogicWeb for component refactors, CSS correctness (grid/flex), and responsive behavior. But at $3/$15, running it as the primary frontend model for heavy daily use costs $13.50/month. Gemini 2.5 Flash at $0.30/$2.50 offers strong design-to-code capability with multimodal input (screenshots → components) at **85% lower cost**. GPT-5.4 was specifically trained "with a focus on improved UI capabilities" per

OpenAI's March 2026 release notes. For vision-to-code from design mockups: **GLM-5V Turbo** ($1.20/$4.00) is the dedicated specialist. Modelos IA: Costo, Open S...

Best model for backend API development

Recommended: DeepSeek V3.2 ($0.26/$0.38) as the primary, with Claude Sonnet 4.6 for complex refactoring. The practitioner consensus is a multi-tier workflow: "use Opus to plan and design, then execute changes elsewhere." Faros DeepSeek V3.2 delivers **~90% of GPT-5.4's quality at 1/50th the cost**, Modelos IA: Costo, Open S... with ~77% SWE-bench Verified. For a solo founder, this means running 95% of backend tasks on DeepSeek and escalating to Claude Sonnet ($3/$15) only for architectural decisions, multi-file refactors, and tricky debugging. Claude Opus 4.6 at **80.8% SWE-bench** is the absolute leader but costs $5/$25— Modelos IA: Costo, Open S...reserve for emergencies. Free option: **Qwen3 Coder:free** (262K context, 78.8% SWE-bench via Qwen lineage) or **Devstral 2:free** (Mistral's 123B agentic coding model with multi-file orchestration).

Danger zone: 12 mistakes that waste money or produce bad output

1. Running DeepSeek for Spanish content. DeepSeek V3.2 is the price-performance king for English, but its European language output is "awkwardly phrased" and confirmed English-first. For any Spanish-facing agent (PLUMA, PROPUESTA, BIENVENIDA, COBRO), use Mistral Large 3.2 or Qwen 3.6 Plus. This is the single most common mistake flagged in the project knowledge.

2. Using Claude Opus 4.6 for routine coding. At $5/$25 per million tokens, Opus burns **$10–$30 in a single afternoon** of agentic coding. The user's own Google Drive document explicitly warns: Opus must be "reserved exclusively for multi-step critical reasoning tasks that are totally unsolvable by smaller networks." Draft with DeepSeek, review with Sonnet.

3. Using Llama 3.3 70B for SQL. Tinybird's SQL Generation Benchmark ranks Llama dead last (#19 of 19): "Only 66% valid queries, weak 52% first attempt rate." Use Claude (ranked #1) or DeepSeek for any database work.

4. Trusting Grok benchmarks at face value. Independent SWE-bench testing found Grok 4 scored **58.6% versus the self-reported 72–75%**—a massive scaffold dependency gap. Grok 4.1 Fast is excellent for tool calling and Twitter, but don't choose it for coding based on xAI's own benchmarks.

5. Using ChatGPT free tier for SEO content. Generic GPT output gets penalized as "generic AI content" in 2026's search landscape. SEO content requires either Claude's natural prose quality or careful prompt engineering with specific keyword density, H2 structure, and CTA constraints.

6. Skipping cross-family code review. If FORGE generates code with DeepSeek V3.2, SENTINEL must use a different model family (GPT-4.1 Mini). Same-model review misses

systematic blind spots. "The teams getting the most value are the ones treating models like a toolbox."

7. Ignoring prompt caching for heavy agents. APEX, FORGE, PIXEL, and HUNTER process millions of tokens monthly. Without caching, you're re-sending the same system prompt and context files with every request. Anthropic's 0.1× cache reads and Google's 90% cache discount can cut costs by **75–90%** on repeated context.

8. Using Gemini 3.1 Pro when Flash suffices. Gemini 3.1 Pro ($2/$12) leads GPQA Diamond at 94.3%, but for monitoring, classification, and data extraction, Gemini 3.1 Flash Lite ($0.25/$1.50) or Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite ($0.10/$0.40) provides sufficient quality at 5–20× lower cost. Reserve Pro for DEEP research tasks.

9. Running all agents on a single model. Vendor lock-in with one provider is, per the user's own document, "inexcusable fiduciary negligence" in 2026. The recommended system uses **8 distinct model families** across 57 agents. If one provider has an outage or price increase, you reroute affected agents without rebuilding the system.

10. Neglecting the free tier rate limits. OpenRouter free models are capped at **20 requests/minute and 200 requests/day** (50/day for some). For heavy agents (APEX, FORGE), free models work for testing but will bottleneck production use. The $10 minimum deposit unlocks higher rate limits immediately.

11. Using GPT for legal citations without verification. A January 2026 database identified **1,153 cases** involving AI-generated hallucinated legal citations—at a rate of 2–3 per day. LEGAL should always have human verification of case citations regardless of model.

12. Choosing models based on AIME 2025 or HumanEval. Both benchmarks are saturated—frontier models score 95–100%. They no longer discriminate quality. Use **SWE-bench Verified** for coding, **GPQA Diamond** for reasoning, **EQ-Bench** for writing, and **BFCL v4** for tool calling.

New models worth watching from March–April 2026

Several releases since the project knowledge was compiled could change optimal assignments:

Qwen 3.6 Plus (free, March 31, 2026) is the biggest game-changer. It's currently the #1 model by usage on OpenRouter, running for free with 1M context and **78.8% SWE-bench**. It handles 5 agents in this system at zero cost and serves as the universal free fallback. Its hybrid linear attention + sparse MoE architecture delivers always-on chain-of-thought reasoning.

GPT-5 Nano ($0.05/$0.40) offers ultra-budget OpenAI quality. For agents where you want OpenAI's structured output guarantees but can't justify GPT-4.1 Mini's cost, Nano is 8× cheaper on input. Not yet tested extensively for this system but worth evaluating for FILTER, PIPELINE, COBRO, and AGENDA.

Llama 4 Maverick ($0.19/$0.60, open-weight) brings a genuinely open 400B MoE model with 1M context. Currently "74% more expensive than DeepSeek V3.2 on OpenRouter" while performing worse on math and reasoning, but its open-weight nature makes it ideal for self-hosting if you later move agents on-premise.

MiMo-V2-Flash (free) is now the #1 open-source model on SWE-bench and processes **4.65 trillion tokens per week** on OpenRouter. Its 309B MoE architecture with hybrid thinking toggle makes it a strong free option for coding agents, though DeepSeek V3.2's paid tier still edges it on complex tasks.

Devstral 2 2512 ($0.05/$0.22, free tier) from Mistral is a 123B agentic coding specialist with notable "frustration tolerance"—it recovers autonomously from iterative failures during multi-file coding. At near-zero cost, it's an excellent free-tier option for DEPLOY and SWIFT.

Conclusion

The fundamental insight driving this system is that **model selection matters more than model spending**. Assigning Mistral Large 3.2 to Spanish agents instead of DeepSeek improves output quality while costing less than a Claude Sonnet fallback. Running Grok 4.1 Fast on TWEET exploits a unique data advantage no premium model can match. Using GPT-4.1 Mini for structured output guarantees schema compliance that even Claude Opus cannot match natively.

At $23.40/month for the value-optimized configuration, a solo founder retains **$176 of monthly headroom** for burst weeks, quality upgrades, and experimentation. The most impactful upgrade path is promoting FORGE, PIXEL, and APEX to Claude Sonnet 4.6 during active development sprints (adding ~$37/month), then dropping back to DeepSeek during maintenance periods. This dynamic allocation—enabled by OpenRouter's model-agnostic routing—is how practitioners achieve premium quality on a budget: not by finding one cheap model for everything, but by spending precisely where quality creates asymmetric returns.